

Interested or interesting?

Teaching guide

Describe a feeling and what causes it.

Understand the distinction

For many pairs, the -ed adjective describes a feeling: bored, excited, interested. The -ing adjective describes what causes that feeling: boring, exciting, interesting.

People can cause feelings too. A person can be interesting, and a story can be exciting. Choose by meaning, not by whether the noun is a person or a thing. After interested in, use a noun or an -ing verb.

Compare the patterns

FEELING

I am interested in photography.

This describes my feeling.

CAUSE

The photographer is interesting.

This person attracts my interest.

ACTIVITY

I am interested in learning more.

Use learning after in.

Read each example and notice how its form changes the meaning. Use these distinctions to choose your answers on the following pages.

Check your understanding

Circle one answer for each question. There is one correct choice among the options shown. Check the answer key after choosing.

1. The long wait made me feel ____ . (bored / boring)

A. bored

B. boring

C. bore

2. Can a person be interesting?

A. No. Only objects can be interesting.

B. Yes. It means the person feels interested.

C. Yes. A person can cause interest.

3. Choose the correction: I am interested in learn Spanish.

A. I am interesting in learning Spanish.

B. I am interested in learning Spanish.

C. I am interested in to learn Spanish.

Choose the best response

Choose the response that fits the situation. Check both its meaning and its grammar.

4. Choose the sentence that describes an activity and the learner's feeling correctly.

- A. The class is challenging, but I feel excited about to learn.
- B. The class is challenging, but I feel exciting about learning.
- C. The class is challenging, but I feel excited about learning.

Review your choices

Use the answer explanations on the next page. If you chose a different answer, find the detail that makes it unsuitable and try the question again.

Practice online

The web lesson gives feedback for the option you select and lets you try again. No written response is required.

Answers and explanation

1. A. bored

Describe the feeling of the person waiting.

B: Boring describes what causes boredom. Bored describes the feeling here.

C: After feel, use the adjective bored to describe this feeling.

2. C. Yes. A person can cause interest.

The distinction is feeling versus cause, not person versus thing.

A: People can cause interest too: an interesting speaker.

B: Interesting describes the effect on others; interested describes the feeling.

3. B. I am interested in learning Spanish.

A verb after this preposition uses the -ing form.

A: Interested describes your feeling. Interesting describes what causes interest.

C: After in, use the -ing form: learning.

4. C. The class is challenging, but I feel excited about learning.

Challenging describes the class; excited describes the feeling.

A: After about, use learning, not to learn.

B: Excited describes the learner's feeling here.

Continue learning

Web lesson and related topics: englishladder.com/grammar-concepts/concept-03.html

A practical teaching sequence

1. Notice (2 minutes)

Read the comparison examples with the learners. Point out the meaning and form that distinguish each pattern.

2. Choose (4 minutes)

Learners select one option for each of the three checks. Keep the answer key covered. Use the selected option's explanation rather than presenting a generic model as feedback.

3. Apply (5 minutes)

Choose the sentence that describes an activity and the learner's feeling correctly.

Learners choose the response that fits this situation. All responses in this activity are multiple choice; do not replace the choices with a written-answer task.

4. Review (3 minutes)

Compare selected options with the key. Use the option-specific notes to explain why a distractor does not fit. Let learners change their selection and try again.

Scope of the answer key

Each question has one correct option among the choices shown. This does not mean that every other way to express the idea is wrong. Preserve the qualifications in the teaching notes.

Feedback criteria

Check both grammatical form and the stated situation. A correct option answers this question; four correct choices do not certify a learner's overall proficiency.